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Not to Another Place

Iran's uranium, and a ruling on goods that leave your hand

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Iran's uranium, and a ruling on goods that leave your hand

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Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

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Iran's top security official has drawn a line around one thing, and it is not a ship or a strait. It is a pile of enriched uranium.

What was said

On Wednesday, 11 November 2026, Mohsen Rezaei, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, told Lebanon's Al Mayadeen TV that Iran "will not remove a single atom of enriched nuclear material". Reuters carried the same message in its own words: Iran will not let even a single particle leave the country. Tasnim, the Iranian outlet close to the security establishment, quoted him: "Even the smallest amount of enriched nuclear material will not be taken out of Iran".

He said Tehran had already told Moscow. That matters, because, as Radio Free Europe notes, "Russia has often been cited as a potential destination for Iran's stockpile of highly enriched uranium." Shipping the material to Russia has been one of the obvious ways to end the nuclear part of the standoff. Rezaei has now closed that door in public.

He also gave a reason. Middle East Eye quotes him: "We need the enriched material to design ships and submarines that work on nuclear energy". Iran, he said, will keep the material and "we will use it ourselves". That is his stated reason, not a settled technical fact. Naval reactors can run on low-enriched uranium, well below the 60 percent to which Iran had enriched the stock the IAEA last counted. What is not in doubt is that he said it.

What is at stake

Before the American and Israeli strikes of June 2025, the International Atomic Energy Agency estimated Iran held 440.9 kilograms of uranium enriched to 60 percent. Both Reuters and Radio Free Europe give that figure, and both say no one knows how much survived or where it is now. Inspectors have not been able to verify it. A further round of strikes came when the current war began on 28 February 2026.

So the material Rezaei refuses to send abroad is material the world cannot count.

Rezaei paired the refusal with a threat. Reuters reports him saying: "Any new US attacks will also be met with targeting US bases far away". He also dismissed reports of a recent Iran–US meeting in Qatar as "pure lies" meant to drive down oil prices.

On the other side, Washington's line is that the nuclear file has to be part of any first round of talks. After the G7 meeting in Paris on 10 November, Secretary of State Marco Rubio told reporters that the economic campaign was working well enough that there was no need for major combat operations. In the Reuters account of those remarks,

published the same day: "We don't need to conduct military strikes if we're achieving the same objective through economic means and economic pressure."

Why the "where" matters

The Rambam learned on 12 November 2026, in the Laws of Agents and Partners, has a ruling that fits. One partner wants to take the shared goods to another city where they sell for more. He even offers to cover any loss. The other partner may still refuse, and the Rambam gives his reason in plain words: "I do not desire to give you the money that is in my possession and then have to pursue you and bring you to court to expropriate it from you". A promise is not the same as goods you can see.

In the nuclear talks, each side is that second partner. The West does not want to accept Iranian promises about material that sits in places no inspector can reach. Iran does not want to hand over its stockpile and then chase guarantees through mediators. Both are saying the same thing about trust from opposite sides. Rezaei's statement means Iran has picked its answer: the material stays where Iran can see it, and where no one else can.

That makes the uranium, not Hormuz, the hardest knot. The strait can reopen with a signature. The stockpile cannot be checked without access, and it cannot leave without Iran agreeing to let it go.

What to watch

- Whether the full Al Mayadeen interview, broadcast later on Wednesday, 11 November 2026, softens or hardens the line.
- Whether Moscow says anything about having been "informed", as Rezaei put it.
- Any IAEA statement on access to the surviving stock.
- Whether a meeting between Rezaei and US Vice President JD Vance is arranged. The Wall Street Journal reported on 11 November that Vance is considering talks and sent a letter in October requesting a meeting, but that no date has been set. Iranian officials have denied that a meeting is planned.

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